This thickly textured, satisfying soup is a Russian classic to enjoy at any time of year and on any occasion. Try it with grated carrots piled on top and chunks of dark rye bread.

borscht

SERVES 4 **PREP** 15 MINS **COOK** 1½ HRS **FREEZE** UP TO 3 MONTHS

3 tbsp butter
2 large beets, coarsely grated
1 onion, coarsely grated
1 carrot, coarsely grated
1 celery rib, coarsely grated
1 x 14oz (400g) can chopped tomatoes
1 garlic clove, crushed (optional)
1¾ quarts (1¾ liters) hot vegetable stock
2 bay leaves
4 cloves
2 tbsp lemon juice
salt and freshly ground black pepper
¾ cup sour cream

1 Melt the butter in a large saucepan over medium heat. Add the beets, onion, carrot, and celery, and cook, stirring, for 5 minutes or until just softened. Add the tomatoes and garlic, if using, and cook for 2–3 minutes, stirring frequently, then stir in the stock.

2 Tie the bay leaves and cloves in a small piece of muslin or cheesecloth and add to the pan. Bring the soup to a boil, then lower the heat, cover, and simmer for 1 hour 20 minutes. Discard the muslin bag, stir in the lemon juice, and season to taste with salt and pepper. Ladle the soup into warm bowls and add a swirl of sour cream to each one.



BEETS
You can find a variety of types of beets at your local farmers' market—red has the richest flavor. Be gentle when washing because heavy scrubbing may damage the skin and cause "bleeding."